

Seven Hebrew Words Every Christian Should Know

אָמֵן • הַלְלוּיָהּ • רוּחַ • תְּשׁוּבָה • אֲמוּנָה • חֶסֶד • שְׁלוֹם

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For readers of *One Word Wiser*

I'm a rabbi. Most of the people who read the Bible with me are Christians, and most of them have never heard it in the language it was written in.

That's not a failing. It's an opening. The Bible you own is a translation, and a good one. But every translation has to choose one English word where the Hebrew holds three. Hear the Hebrew once, and a verse you've read a hundred times opens a little wider.

Here are seven words. You say some of them already. Say each one out loud. Then read the verse. That's all.

— *Rabbi Evan*

שָׁלוֹם

shalom

PEACE, WHOLENESS

SAY IT. *Sha-LOME*. The stress on the second syllable, the *o* long, as in *home*.

THE PICTURE. *Shalom* comes from *shalem*: whole, complete, nothing missing. A wall with no gap in it is *shalem*. The verb for paying off a debt comes from the same root. So peace, in Hebrew, was never just quiet. It is the state of a thing with all its parts. When two people make *shalom*, they aren't calling a truce. They are being made whole again, together.

ONE VERSE.

The LORD lift up His face toward you, and give you *shalom*. (Numbers 6:26, my translation)

That is the last line of the priestly blessing, the oldest blessing still spoken in synagogues and churches. Notice what it ends on. Light, grace, the lifted face, and then *shalom*, the thing that holds all the rest.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. On the evening of the first Easter, Jesus stands in a locked room and says one word to his frightened friends. Your Bible has "Peace be with you!" (John 20:19). The Greek word there is the one the Greek Bible uses for *shalom*, and under it is the greeting every Jew said and still says: *shalom aleichem*. Not "calm down." Be whole.

Peace is not quiet. Peace is nothing missing.



LOYAL LOVE

SAY IT. *CHEH-sed*. The first sound comes from the back of the throat, like the *ch* in Bach. Stress on the first syllable.

THE PICTURE. English has never found the word. Your Bible says "mercy," "lovingkindness," "steadfast love," sometimes just "love," and each one gets a piece. *Chesed* is love that keeps its promises. Love with a spine. It is what Ruth does when she refuses to leave Naomi; the book of Ruth names it three times. Not a feeling that comes over you. A loyalty you act on, especially when no one would blame you for walking away.

ONE VERSE.

Give thanks to the LORD, for He is good; His *chesed* is forever. (Psalm 136:1, my translation)

Twenty-six times that psalm says it: *ki l'olam chasdo*. The line is a refrain because *chesed* is the thing that repeats.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. Jesus quotes Hosea to the Pharisees, twice: "I desire mercy, not sacrifice" (Matthew 9:13; 12:7). The word under "mercy" is *chesed* (Hosea 6:6). He isn't asking them to feel sorrier. He is asking for loyal love.

Chesed is love that shows up again tomorrow.



FAITH, STEADINESS

SAY IT. *Eh-moo-NAH*. Stress at the end. Say *amen* right after it and hear the same root.

THE PICTURE. *Emunah* comes from *aman*: firm, steady, something you can lean your weight on. A nurse who carries a child is an *omen* in Hebrew, from the same root, because the child is safe in those arms (Numbers 11:12). In Exodus, Moses stands on a hill with his hands raised over the battle below. When his arms tire, two men hold them up, "and his hands were *emunah* until the sun went down" (Exodus 17:12). That is the first time the Bible uses the word. Not a belief he held. Hands that were held.

ONE VERSE.

— The righteous one lives by his *emunah*. (Habakkuk 2:4, my translation)

Not by his certainty. By his steadiness.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. That line from Habakkuk is quoted three times in the New Testament (Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:38), and it became the sentence the Reformation was built on: "The righteous will live by faith." Under "faith" is *emunah*: a hand held steady until sunset.

Faith, in Hebrew, is hands held steady until the sun goes down.

תשובה

teshuvah

RETURN

SAY IT. *Teb-shoo-VAH*. Stress on the last syllable, like a step landing on a doorstep.

THE PICTURE. Your Bible says "repentance." Put that down for a minute. *Teshuvah* grows from *shuv*, to turn around, to come back, one of the most common verbs in the Hebrew Bible, and almost always physical. The dove comes back to Noah's ark; the word is *shuv*. Naomi comes home to Bethlehem; *shuv* again. Repentance, in English, is a feeling, from a Latin word for penalty. *Teshuvah* is a direction. You were walking one way. You turn around. You walk back. Nobody asks how bad you feel. They ask which way you are facing.

ONE VERSE.

And you will return to the LORD your God, and listen to His voice, with all your heart and all your soul. (Deuteronomy 30:2, my translation)

V'shavta. The Torah says it as a promise, not a threat: you will come back.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. The first word of Jesus's preaching is "Repent" (Mark 1:15). In Hebrew ears that is *shuvu*: turn around, come home. And the son in Luke 15 doesn't feel his way back to his father. "He got up and went" (Luke 15:20).

You don't have to feel worse. You have to face the other way.

רוּחַ

ruach

WIND, BREATH, SPIRIT

SAY IT. *ROO-ach*. The last sound scrapes the back of the throat; let it. One syllable and a half.

THE PICTURE. One word, three meanings, and the Hebrew never chooses. *Ruach* is the wind that moves the trees, the breath that moves your chest, and the Spirit that moves over the deep. Every translator has to pick one. The Hebrew reader gets all three at once. In Ezekiel's valley of dry bones, the prophet calls to the *ruach* to come "from the four winds" and breathe on the dead (Ezekiel 37:9): wind, breath and spirit in one sentence, and the bones stand up.

ONE VERSE.

And the *ruach* of God hovered over the face of the waters. (Genesis 1:2, my translation)

The second verse of the Bible, before light. Wind, or breath, or Spirit. The Hebrew won't say which, because it is all three.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. Jesus tells Nicodemus, "The wind blows wherever it pleases... So it is with everyone born of the Spirit" (John 3:8). In Greek, as in Hebrew, that is one word doing both jobs. The sentence is a play on *ruach*, and it only works if you hear the double meaning.

Wind, breath, Spirit. The Hebrew won't choose, so you get all three.

הללויה

hallelujah

PRAISE THE LORD

SAY IT. *Ha-le-LOO-yah*. You already know how. It is the one Hebrew word the Church never translated.

THE PICTURE. It is not one word but two. *Hallelu* is a command in the plural: praise, all of you. *Yah* is the short form of God's name, the one hiding inside *Isaiah* and *Elijah*. So *hallelujah* is not a sigh of happiness. It is an order given to a crowd: praise Him, everyone. The last five psalms each open and close with it, like a doorframe. And it crossed into Greek, then Latin, then English, letter for letter, because no one could find a better word.

ONE VERSE.

Let every breath praise the LORD. *Hallelujah!* (Psalm 150:6, my translation)

The last line of the last psalm. *Kol baneshamah*: every breath, every soul, every thing that breathes.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. Handel took the word from Revelation 19, the only place the New Testament says it: "Hallelujah! For our Lord God Almighty reigns" (Revelation 19:6). John wrote it in Greek letters, but the word he wrote was Hebrew.

Hallelujah is a command, given to a crowd: praise Him, all of you.

אָמֵן

amen

SO BE IT

SAY IT. *Ab-MEN*. Stress at the end. However your church says it, you are saying Hebrew.

THE PICTURE. *Amen* is *emunah*'s little brother, from the same root, *aman*: firm, steady, trustworthy. To say *amen* is not to say "the end." It is to say "I stand on that." In the Bible it is an answer. Someone else speaks first, a blessing or a vow, and the people answer *amen*: we take it as ours. That is why one voice says the blessing and the whole room says the last word.

ONE VERSE.

And all the people shall say, *Amen*. (Deuteronomy 27:15, my translation)

Twelve times on Mount Ebal the Levites call out, and twelve times the whole people answer with one word.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. Jesus turns the word around. In the Hebrew Bible, *amen* answers; someone else speaks first. Jesus opens with it: "Very truly I tell you" is *amen*, *amen* (John 1:51, and twenty-four more times in John). He is saying: stand on this. And Revelation gives him the word as a name: "the Amen, the faithful and true witness" (Revelation 3:14).

Amen doesn't mean "the end." It means "I stand on that."

One Hebrew word arrives every morning at rabbi.substack.com.

Send me a verse. Any verse. I'll show you the Hebrew underneath.

— *Rabbi Evan*

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